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Google just made back-button hijacking a spam offense. Here's what you need to do.

Google's new spam policy targets a dark UX pattern that has quietly eroded reader trust for years. Here's what it means for your traffic, your revenue, and your relationship with the open web.



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SPAM



A few weeks ago, Google's Search team quietly published something that every publisher, ad-ops professional, and revenue strategist in our industry should have bookmarked by now. They have now formally [announced back-button hijacking](#), a spam classification for a practice that has been living in a grey zone for far too long.

You've probably experienced it yourself.

Now, let me be direct: if you're a publisher monetising through display advertising and you haven't audited your site or your ad partners for this behaviour, you're sitting on a ticking clock. Full stop.

What exactly is Back-Button Hijacking?

When a user hits the back button, they expect to go back. Back-button hijacking breaks that. It works by injecting phantom entries into the browser's session history, so instead of leaving your site, the user gets bounced to another page on it, or gets stuck in a loop.

The motive was always pageviews. More impressions, more ad revenue. But it was always short-term thinking. However, Google has drawn a clear line:

"Manipulating browser navigation to retain users against their will is now a spam signal, not a monetisation strategy."

Why it matters to you right now

The immediate risk is a Google search ranking penalty. For most publishers, organic search is still their largest traffic source. A demotion hurts fast.

But there's a slower burn, too. Programmatic buyers are getting better at filtering low-quality traffic. Inflated sessions from navigation manipulation don't convert, don't engage, and increasingly get flagged by DSP-side quality tools. The CPM you're earning on that traffic is already being discounted.

The irony is that the publishers most likely to be affected didn't build this themselves. It came in through ad tags, third-party scripts, or monetisation partners, bundled in without anyone fully auditing what it was doing to the browser.

Three things to do this week

- Audit your session history on page load. Open DevTools, load a page, and check how many history entries exist before you've clicked anything. More than one is a red flag.
- Review every third-party script on your site. Ad tags, recommendation widgets, monetisation SDKs, and anything that injects JavaScript need to be checked. If a partner can't confirm compliance with Google's new policy, that's your answer.
- Have the conversation with your ad ops and tech teams now, not after a penalty. Remediation is straightforward. Recovering from a Google manual action is not.

The underlying message from Google is consistent with everything they've pushed over the last few years: UX quality is an infrastructure cost, not a nice-to-have. Publishers who treat it that way tend to build something durable; the ones who don't tend to keep firefighting.

If you're a publisher trying to make sense of how this policy affects your specific setup, whether that's a direct-sold premium model, an open exchange stack, or a hybrid, I'm genuinely happy to talk through it. While the transition is manageable, the cost of ignoring it is not.

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